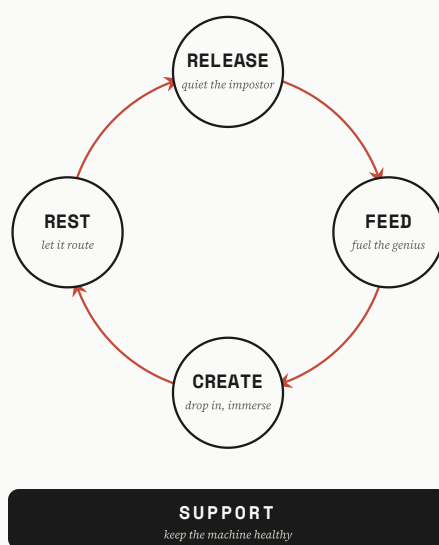


The Genius Toolkit

This is an overview of how I try to get myself into Genius Mode and stay there (and everyone has a Genius Mode!). The principles are the same for everyone. Tailor the specifics to your needs.



This is the virtuous cycle that I aim to stay in. Quiet the Impostor, Feed your mind (learn) to expand what you're capable of, Create work that draws from what you've learned, and Rest in various ways to toggle between multiple brain states. Underneath it all is the foundation that keeps the organ it depends on in good working condition.

How this works

Your best work comes from a part of you that runs on its own, underneath your attention. Most of what feels like effort and worry comes from the other part, the clueless conscious narrator who takes the credit and does the fretting. This is a short guide to setting up your days so the first part has room to do its job and the second part gets out of the way.

In its ideal form, it's a virtuous cycle. You **Release** the Impostor's story about what you can and can't do, you **Feed** your mind with raw material and new skills, you **Create** using your knowledge and skills, and you **Rest** so what you've fed it can sort itself out. Then you come back around. Underneath all four sits **Support**: sleep, movement, and staying curious, the upkeep that keeps the neural machinery in good working condition.

As we all know, in the modern world it's all too easy for our best intentions to be derailed by distractions. So there's an overarching strategy to defend against it: make the good work easy to start and the time-wasting hard to reach. Nearly everything that follows is some version of that.

For each component, you'll learn why it matters, the kinds of tools that help, and some of the specific ones I rely on regularly. Mine aren't a prescription, just specific examples to help make it concrete. The last page is blank and yours to fill in.

But it all begins on the very next page, with the one move that has to come first.

Change the story

Before any tool in this kit does a thing, one move has to come first. It's dead simple but not easy: change the story you tell about yourself. The Impostor's only real power is shaping what you do next, which means you become whoever your story says you are. Change the story and everything downstream changes with it.

So look at what the usual stories do. If your story is “I'm smart,” or “I'm musical,” or “I'm an athlete,” then every challenge is a threat to the label and every mistake is evidence against you, and the safest move is always not to try.

But make the story “I'm a lifelong learner” and everything reverses. Challenges become the whole point. Mistakes become proof you're doing the thing. There's nothing left to protect, because trying badly at something new is exactly what a learner does.

To the Genius, struggle is feedback. To the Impostor, struggle is a verdict.

Here's the key ninja move: the Impostor's job is to protect your identity, whatever it is. Make your identity “learner,” and the only way he can protect it is to help you learn. You've turned him into the Genius.

That's the first domino. Nothing else matters until it falls.

MOVE ONE

Release

Quiet the Impostor

WHY THIS ONE MATTERS

There's a voice in your head that keeps a running story about what you are and aren't capable of. It feels like plain fact, because it sounds like you and it's been talking your whole life. But it isn't reporting the truth. It's a narrator protecting a version of you that never has to risk trying and failing, and when you believe it, you skip the work that would prove it wrong, so it gets to stay right. It's the same voice that spikes right before something matters.

You quiet that voice in two ways: by getting some distance from its story, and by taking the spotlight off yourself, so it has less to protect and less to say.

THE KINDS OF TOOLS

- **Give the voice a name.** When the voice is “you,” its story about what you can't do lands as fact. Give the voice a name that isn't yours and it turns into a character you can catch telling the same old story. If you want some help in assigning your Impostor a fitting name, click on this [Impostor Naming Tool](#).
- **Lose yourself.** A sky full of stars, a piece of music, anything that makes you feel connected with something much larger.
- **Do something for someone else.** The fastest way out of your own head is to be useful in somebody else's.
- **A practice for watching thoughts.** An app that teaches you to observe a thought instead of believe it ([Waking Up](#), or the free [Healthy Minds Program](#)) trains the exact skill this whole page runs on.
- **A throwaway notebook.** A few pages of private longhand each morning. The voice's material lands on paper, where you can finally look at it from a distance.
- **Make the Impostor's habits hard to reach.** The apps that feed comparison (e.g. social media!) should take real effort to open. A blocker that adds a pause works; deleting the app and keeping it browser-only works better.
- **One named swap.** Write down three activities where you lose yourself and three where the voice gets loud. Then trade one for one, and name it: “thirty minutes reading before bed,” not “read more.”

To go deeper on the voice in your head and how to turn it down, two books do it well: Chatter by Ethan Kross, and The Happiness Trap by Russ Harris.

WHAT I DO

I named my Impostor years ago, and once you've done that you can hear it coming. I get outside myself by getting out in nature, stargazing, and awe-inspiring music. I listen to stand up comedy, because it's hard to feel important while you're laughing. And I make social media a genuine pain to get to. If it weren't useful for some of my work, I'm not sure I'd use it at all.

MOVE TWO

Feed

Fuel the Genius

WHY THIS ONE MATTERS

The part of you that has ideas works by connecting patterns, so the more patterns you feed it, the more it has to work with. And to your brain, a pattern is a pattern. A tennis swing, a chord change, a dance step, the rhythm of a sentence: it files them all the same way.

The best new ideas tend to come from noticing that two of them, from fields that look nothing alike, are the same shape underneath. So reading isn't the only way to feed it. Learning a skill of any kind does it, and movement does it best, because your brain was built to move. That's cross-training, and it shows up in who reaches the top: Nobel-winning scientists are over 20 times more likely than their peers to also be performers, musicians, and artists.

How do you choose what to feed it? **Follow your curiosity**, even when it looks impractical.

Curiosity is how your Genius tells you what it's ready to learn, and attention follows what you care about, so the interesting thing is also the thing that sticks. There's a bonus most people miss: if your reading and watching match everyone else's, your ideas will too. The odd interests are where the original connections come from. Try this: write down three topics you've been drawn to but dismissed as impractical, and go explore one this week.

THE KINDS OF TOOLS

- **Things to read and listen to.** Books, podcasts, and conversations with people who know things you don't.
- **A library card.** The cheapest all-you-can-read pass ever made, and the [Libby](#) app puts the whole thing on your phone for free.
- **A way to catch ideas.** A notebook, a notes app, a voice memo. The best one is whatever's in your hand when the idea hits.

- **Skills you keep sharp.** The ones you've built stay with a little regular use: a sport, an instrument, a craft. Joining a team or a class turns it into a promise you'll keep.
- **A new skill you're bad at.** Always have one going. It's cheap to start: a ukulele, a deck of cards, juggling balls, a pair of tap shoes. It's easier than it's ever been to learn anything.

WHAT I DO

I read fiction at night, nonfiction in the morning and throughout the day - a mix of digital and paperback. I have books within arms reach at any of my common workstations around the house (plus a pencil for underlining!). Podcasts and audiobooks are going in the car. The moment an idea hits, it goes into a single draft email that gets sorted into my files for me each day (or a voice memo if typing isn't possible). And I treat skills like part of the diet. I keep up the ones I've built like racket sports and playing music, and I always have a new one I'm bad at going. Right now that's tap dancing and five ball juggling!

MOVE THREE

Create

Drop in, immerse

WHY THIS ONE MATTERS

Focused work is a state, and states can be trained. Your brain can be conditioned to enter into certain states more easily. When you pair the same signals with the same kind of work, a certain sound, a certain chair, a certain time of day, it learns the pattern. Keep using that pattern, and after a while the focus is triggered automatically, before you've had to talk yourself into it.

THE KINDS OF TOOLS

- **A sound you use only for this.** A track, an album, an app. It becomes the “we're working now” bell.
- **A spot for each kind of work.** When a place means one thing, sitting down there starts the engine. Different work, different spot, so the signals stay clean.
- **A tool you actually like.** A pen you enjoy holding gets you writing. And by hand, different ideas come out than on a screen.
- **A ritual you can repeat.** Do the same thing at the same time each day, and after a while it's enough to start the work on its own.

ONCE YOU'RE IN: MAKE THINGS

Consuming feels productive, and it's perfectly safe, because you can't fail at reading one more article. But watching is not building. You only grow by making things: write the argument instead of just reading the history, play the tune instead of watching another lesson.

Making something is also the only honest test of what you actually understand. Expect it to feel like a strain, because the strain is what grows you. A brain only changes when it's working at the edge of what it can do. And the right struggle has a size: hard enough that you're missing about one try in five. Easier than that and nothing is changing. Harder and you can't tell what to fix.

This is why a one-on-one tutor beats every other way of learning we've ever tested. A tutor re-calibrates the difficulty as you grow, keeping the

struggle tailored to where your brain is today.

- **A visible timer.** Set it for twenty-five minutes and make the ugliest first version of the thing. The magic is in the editing. Having to produce in a limited time frame lowers the expectations, and quiets the voice.
- **Anything with levels.** A chess app that matches your rating, a climbing gym's graded routes, a music book that goes step by step, a teacher. These hold you at the right difficulty automatically.
- **An AI, used as a tutor.** [Claude](#) or [ChatGPT](#) is the most powerful difficulty-matcher ever built, if you use it right. One question sorts good use from bad: is this a forklift or a deadlift? “Give me the answer” lifts the weight for you, and you get nothing. “Coach me through this, one step at a time” is a patient, expert tutor that meets you exactly where you are, which used to be a luxury almost nobody had.
- **Materials too cheap to be precious.** A ream of cheap printer paper, a bargain sketchbook, a drafts folder nothing leaves. If the page feels expensive, you'll start judging the work before it exists.

WRITE TO THINK

One kind of making deserves singling out, because it's the most powerful thinking tool there is: writing. We treat it as a way to hand over ideas we've already worked out, but most of the thinking actually happens in the writing. A thought can sit in your head as a warm, agreeable blur and feel finished. Try to put it in a sentence and the gaps show up, and closing them is the thinking. Language isn't only how we pass ideas around. It's the technology we think with. Writing by hand works even better than typing: it's slow enough to keep pace with the thought, and there's nothing on the page trying to pull you away.

WHAT I DO

brain.fm and a pair of noise-canceling headphones are my “now we work” signal. I write in one spot and compose music in another, so my brain always knows which one it's in. I keep pens and pencils around that I actually like to hold and write with, because I think better by hand. And a Stumptown cold brew right after lunch is the bell that means it's time to write.

MOVE FOUR

Rest

Let it route

WHY THIS ONE MATTERS

Your best ideas don't show up at your desk. They show up in the shower, on a walk, on a bike. When you stop working a problem on purpose, a different set of brain regions picks it up and keeps turning it over without you. This part of the loop looks like doing nothing, and that's the whole point. **It only works if you genuinely step away**, which is harder than it sounds, so most of these tools are really just ways to make yourself do it.

THE KINDS OF TOOLS

- **A walk with no phone.** The phone is the off-switch for this whole mode. Leave it home.
- **Your instrument, or your hands, for fun.** Play something you already know, just for the enjoyment of it. Any overlearned and automatic activity with your hands will work (knitting, gardening, dishes, etc.)
- **A cheap bike, ridden like a kid.** Not for exercise, just for the ride.
- **A standing walk with someone you love.** The company is what gets you out the door.
- **A guided rest recording.** If you can't nap, search “NSDR” or “yoga nidra.” Free, and it walks you into the same territory.

WHAT I DO

Every evening I walk with my wife, and that one holds because it's a promise to her, not to me. When I'm stuck, I grab the banjo (like books, an instrument is always within arms reach) and play tunes I already know, no plan and no practice. And I ride a cheap old bike around the neighborhood the way I did as a kid. Some of my best ideas show up right there.

THE FOUNDATION

Support

Keep the machine healthy

WHY THIS ONE MATTERS

None of the loop runs well on a tired, stale brain. Support is the plain upkeep underneath everything else: sleep you can count on, a body that moves, sunlight early in the day. It's the least glamorous part, but the one everything else depends on. Skimp here and every other action loses its impact. The new skill you keep going over in Feed pays off here too, because staying a beginner at something is one of the best ways we know to keep a brain sharp as it ages.

THE KINDS OF TOOLS

- **A sleep routine you keep.** The same sleep and wake time does more than any trick. Add a wind-down without bright screens, a dark room, whatever quiet you need.
- **Movement you'll actually do.** It doesn't have to be a workout. A walk, a ride, a game, a minute of balance between tasks. Just move your body, regularly. That's literally what your brain was built for.
- **Daylight, early.** Get outside soon after you wake. Morning light sets your body clock better than anything in a bottle.
- **Coffee on a schedule, if desired.** Same amount, same time, so it stays a tool instead of a lever you keep pulling. There's considerable evidence that coffee (with caffeine) is good for the brain over the long term.

WHAT I DO

I sleep and wake at the same times, held in place by a white noise app that also wakes me in the morning. (If you tend to check your phone in the night, a plain white noise machine is the safer call.) I read in bed on a Kindle so there's no blue light, and I wear a sleep mask. And there's a little blue balance block, juggling balls, and a jump rope by my desk to help me remember to take movement breaks.

NOW MAKE IT **YOURS**

Your Toolkit

The moves are standard-issue. The tools are personal. Write in what works for you, and keep changing it as you learn what does.

THE STORY *who is building all this?*

RELEASE *quiet the impostor*

FEED *fuel the genius*

CREATE *drop in, immerse*

REST *let it route*

SUPPORT *keep the machine healthy*

YOUR TOOLKIT

GENIUSANDIMPOSTOR.COM

The tools

Every named tool, in one place. Free ones are marked, and nothing here is an affiliate link - just the honest source.

RELEASE

The Impostor Namer FREE	geniusandimpostor.com/impostor-namer
Waking Up — watching thoughts	wakingup.com
Healthy Minds Program FREE	humin.org
one sec — adds a pause before an app opens	one-sec.app
Freedom / Cold Turkey — scheduled blocks	freedom.to · getcoldturkey.com
<i>Chatter</i> , Ethan Kross · <i>The Happiness Trap</i> , Russ Harris	books

FEED

Libby — library books & audiobooks FREE	libbyapp.com
YouTube — a teacher for nearly any skill FREE	youtube.com

CREATE

Brain.fm — focus sound	brain.fm
Lichess — chess matched to your level FREE	lichess.org
Claude — AI tutor	claude.ai
ChatGPT — AI tutor	chatgpt.com

REST

NSDR / yoga nidra — guided rest FREE	search on YouTube
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SUPPORT

A white noise machine, a sleep mask, a Kindle, a balance board	any retailer
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